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FLYING HIGH
(top) Kumail Nanjiani in a still from *The Big Sick* (2017); Nanjiani as Kingo in *Eternals* (2021)

Much before films like *The Full Monty* [1997] and *Magic Mike* [2012] delighted female audiences, there was their inspiration, Chippendales, a Los Angeles-based night club whose main attraction was male strippers who flaunted both their bodies and dance moves. The club, which would go on to become a popular franchise and then a dance company that continues to tour to date, was started by Bombay-born Indian American Somen 'Steve' Banerjee. Pakistani American comic, writer and actor Kumail Nanjiani was surprised that he hadn't heard of this "immigrant success story". He connected with it on many levels: there was Banerjee's quest to find acceptance in a new world, much like Nanjiani when he came from Pakistan to study in Iowa at the age of 18. Then there was the desire to achieve the 'American dream'.

Now, with Nanjiani in the lead role, Hulu series *Welcome to Chippendales,* based on the rise and fall of the shy man who was a Hugh Hefner-worshipping teetotaller, will premiere on Disney+Hotstar soon. "Towards the end of the show, he says certain things that I feel I could assert," says Nanjiani. "Hopefully, where we differ is in our control of anger and emotional maturity." That's because Banerjee became a parable for how greed can be a man's undoing. In 1994, he pleaded guilty to hiring a killer to murder Nick De Noia, a show producer at Chippendales, and for plotting to knock off a few of the club's dancers. He would die of suicide in 1994, just before he was to face a verdict for these crimes.

Audiences, especially in the Indian subcontinent, will appreciate how Nanjiani nails the speech of a fresh-off-the-boat desi guy. The actor based the accent on "a very famous Indian director", whose name he refused to divulge. A little bit of Hindi also makes its way into the show, especially in scenes that feature Banerjee and his mother who lived in Bombay.

What the show does particularly well is tap into the insecurities of an immigrant. Somen changed his name to Steve and dressed in suits and expensive watches so as not to be undermined as a businessman. "It is a very obvious way of trying to fit into a world where he is surrounded by white men," says Nanjiani. "He is a king of a world that wouldn't actually welcome him unless he was the king."

Welcome to Chippendales **is more evidence of OTT platforms as cheerleaders of diversity in American entertainment**

The eight-episode series with a brown desi lead is proof of how streaming platforms have become cheerleaders of diversity in American entertainment. With shows like *Never Have I Ever* (2020—) and *Ms. Marvel* (2022), they are breaking stereotypes to tell insightful stories about the South Asian community. "Now you can tell stories not just from diverse points of view, but anything with even a narrow appeal can be made," says Nanjiani, adding that Chippendales has a wider appeal given its place in American pop culture.

Nanjiani joins the likes of Mindy Kaling and Aziz Ansari, who have established a firm foothold in the US entertainment industry. Apart from being a series regular in the popular sitcom *Silicon Valley* (2014-2019), he made inroads into Hollywood with *The Big Sick* (2017), a rom-com he starred in and co-wrote with his wife Emily V. Gordon, and which is inspired by their own love story. The duo would go on to be nominated for an original screenplay Oscar. For many, though, he's best known as Kingo from the Marvel film *Eternals* (2021), for which the actor slogged it out in the gym to develop the six-pack abs of a Bollywood star. Asked whether he would want to do a Hindi film someday, he names S.S. Rajamouli as a preferred collaborator.

Currently, however, work in the US is keeping Nanjiani busy. But he admits that having more options doesn't always translate into good work. "Still, really great projects like this one [*Welcome to Chippendales*] are fairly rare," he says. "There is a lot that people want to make that I don't connect with or [things] are made for the wrong reasons, which will always be a losing proposition. The challenge has been to figure out what I really want to do and not do something that will just help my career. I'd rather make my own mistakes than be a victim to someone else's."

So far, Nanjiani appears to be making all the right moves. ■

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